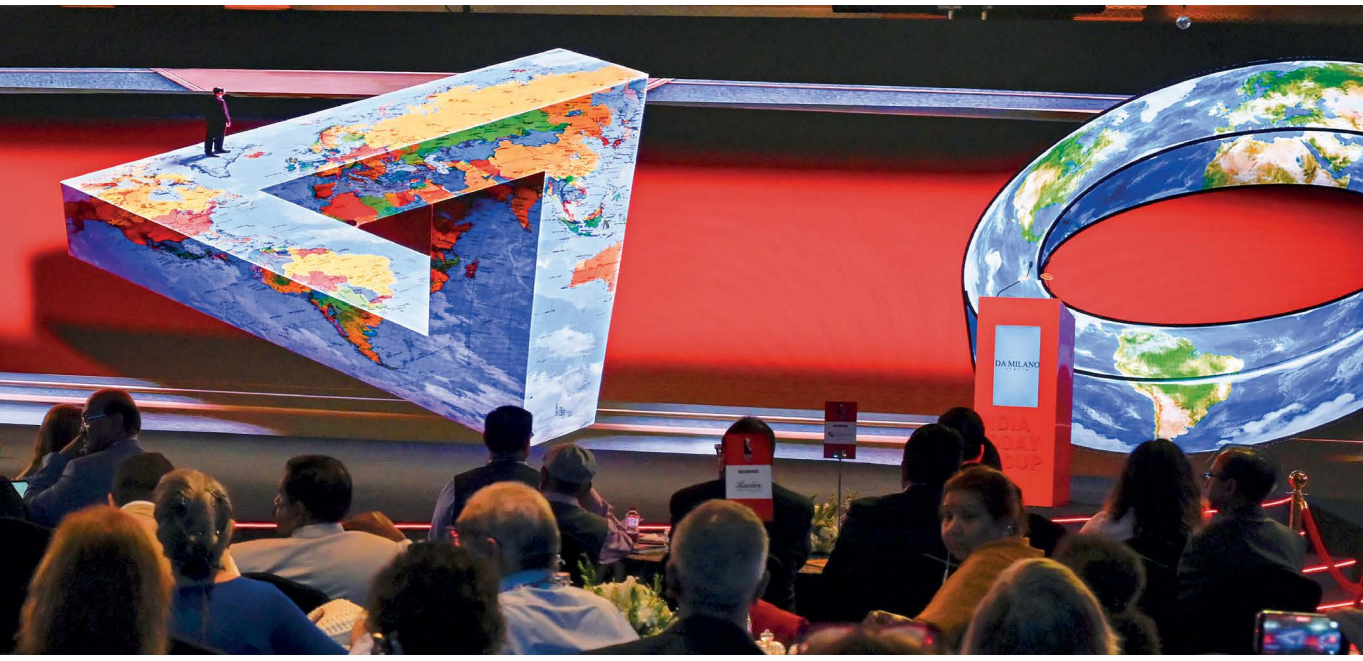
CHANDRADEEP KUMAR



Democracies rarely collapse overnight, they weaken gradually. Democracy needs oxygen. And that oxygen is free speech and a vibrant media

exchange our values for efficiency, we lose. In all this turbulence and transformation, we must remain anchored in our ethics and our independence of judgement.

As an aside, I am sometimes asked whether a robot will one day replace the editor of INDIA TODAY. My wife might say a robot who does her bidding without question would certainly be easier to live with! But journalism is not only about processing information. It is about sensing reality—the atmosphere, the voices, the sentiments, the tensions of a moment. No machine can fully replicate that. AI will help journalists tell richer stories, but a human must remain in the driving seat, with one foot on the brake. So, I think I will still have a job. And my wife will continue to suffer me till AI improves.

Beyond technology, we are also witnessing geopolitical shifts. Globalisation, once the engine of growth, is under strain. Supply chains are fragmenting. Trade is becoming politicised. Efficiency is increasingly being sacrificed at the altar of security. Yet there is also a breakthrough hidden within this disruption. President Donald Trump's bid to reassert American dominance in his second term has without doubt unsettled the old global order. But that has resulted in the world becoming more multipolar, more contested and more fluid. For countries like India, this creates space—economic, diplomatic and strategic. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has ensured that India's voice carries greater weight today than at any time in our post-Independence history.

But there are deeper breakdowns we must confront. Climate change is no longer a distant threat; it is a present reality. Extreme weather, water stress and food insecurity are already reshaping economies and politics. The tragedy is that solutions are available, but collective resolve remains inadequate. And then there is the erosion of trust. Trust in institutions. Trust in information. Trust in leadership. Democracies rarely collapse overnight. They weaken gradually, when conversation gives way to shouting, when disagreement becomes disloyalty and when facts become optional. Democracy needs oxygen. And that oxygen is free speech and a vibrant media. That is why platforms like the India Today conclave matter.

For more than two decades, this gathering has brought together leaders, thinkers and critics, not to manufacture agreement, but to sharpen understanding. In an age defined by breakthroughs and breakdowns, this role becomes even more important. The defining question before us is not whether the world will change. It already has. The real questions are whether we can convert breakthroughs into lasting progress without triggering dangerous breakdowns. Can innovation coexist with inclusion? Can growth align with sustainability? Can power be exercised with restraint?

You may not like the answers, but you must engage with them. Because in times like these, the greatest danger is not disruption. It is complacency. ■

To watch the full session, visit **https://bitly.cx/T07w**